of Orthodox peoples are Slav, there are exceptions. The Romanians and the Greeks are two Orthodox nations that are not Slavic, and the Romanians have a further distinction – not only do they write in a Latin script, they also speak a Latin language, the closest you can get to Italian anywhere in the world. There is more than religion and script when it comes to things Orthodox!

After the fall of the Western Roman Empire, the Eastern Empire used to be referred to simply as the Roman Empire, which reflected the fact that it regarded itself (rightfully so, as we saw in the first chapter) as the real heir to Rome and as the (only) true defender of the Christian faith. It only began to be called ‘Byzantium’ after its fall in 1453; it got the name from a small town near Constantinople/Istanbul. (Interestingly, in some Slavic languages such as Slovenian, it is still called ‘Carigrad’, that is, the city of the Tsar or Emperor.)

While over the centuries Byzantium was more or less able to subdue or contain the military threat of the Bulgarians and the Slavs, their Muslim adversaries had gradually emerged as their most dangerous enemies. In addition, Byzantium was a theocratic state, its leaders taking theological issues very seriously – as seriously as perhaps only Charlemagne did in the West. Gradually this became a political problem in its relations with the West, where the papacy grew more and more distant from Constantinople – and vice versa. Increasingly, the Holy Roman Empire on one hand and the Roman Empire of Constantinople on the other became irrelevant to each other in both a political and a religious sense. The preoccupation of Byzantium with the Slavs and later with the Arabs and the Ottomans, as well as the physical barriers (the wedge of Slavs between the two empires) exacerbated the problem. The theological differences were further complicated by disagreement over the Crusades. Ultimately, Byzantium was sacked by the Crusaders in 1204, which is still an issue for the Orthodox Church even today. There were attempts to restore the empire and the union of the Church but, with only reluctant help offered by the West against the Ottomans, often conditional on doctrinal alignment, Byzantium never really recovered. It was finally defeated by the Ottomans in 1453 and became Istanbul.

The later developments are the subject of the next chapter, which will show that it was during the Ottoman era that the term ‘Eastern’ finally